another to shore up home base Thane, which he's trying to bolt up against an interested BJP.

Verbal shelling is intense. Sanjay Shirat, the Sena's social justice minister, is crying foul over Rs 425 crore of his outlay being diverted to Ladki Bahin. In a stinging reproof, he's calling out "Shakunis" in the finance department, a veiled reference to Ajit, saying the pre-poll promise of a hike in the scheme's payout will be chimeric. The most intense sniping is in Raigad, where the Sena called state NCP chief and Lok Sabha MP Sunil Tatkare a "cheat", blocked his daughter's path to being guardian minister; Tatkare publicly mimicked a Shinde minister.

Is there a method to all this? A tentative strategy looms vis-a-vis a key event on the calendar: urban and local body polls. Will the trio at all contest together? An NCP senior hints at separate battlefield presences, rather than a coalition of the unwilling. A BJP elder seconds this, saying it makes sense for the Mahayuti to split

Takeaways

- **Ajit, Shinde have both been inducting defectors so as to cut each other down to size**
- **BJP, NCP hint at Mahayuti trio fighting crucial local body polls separately to max gains**

the pro-incumbency and opposition spaces between themselves to edge out an already-weakened Maha Vikas Aghadi. It's just that Shinde's diminution seems part of the plan. Even if, as a loyalist says, he shares good vibes with the BJP top tiers and the tussle is only local. "Here, the BJP is signalling it's Big Brother. Ajit has adjusted but Shinde is in no mood to," says analyst Sandeep Pradhan. For now, Mahayuti optics are being set by not-so-friendly fire between alliance partners. ■

▶ BIHAR

MODI SUNRISE, NITISH ECLIPSE

The BJP wants to retain all the goodwill Brand Nitish will bring it for the Bihar poll—but not much more

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

PAHALGAM TO PATNA. As political horizons, they are over a thousand miles apart. But Prime Minister Narendra Modi had collapsed the distance on April 24, when he chose Madhubani as the unlikely stage from where to promise retribution against Pakistan. When he returned to Bihar at the end of May, the public sphere still sizzled with the acrid residues of Operation Sindoor. The right atmospherics, then, for him to talk of mission accomplished—yoking Bihar to the spinning wheels of a larger narrative.

Not that it was all abstract. Modi's 32-minute elocution at Bikramganj, Rohtas district, wove the local and national together like warp and woof, holding forth on growth, welfare, the end of Maoism et al, lobbing in barbs at the Opposition to spice things up. Something was conspicuous by its absence too: a clear endorsement of Nitish Kumar as a chief ministerial face.

NO MORE THE GROOM?

The Janata Dal (United) was hoping a de facto coronation would come, since only months are left for the Bihar assembly election. The PM did praise Nitish, but stopped right there on that intriguing edge. Maybe because it was an official vis-



FOR THE CAMERAS Modi greets Nitish during a function at Karakat in Bihar, May 30